

Challenge Your English: Collocations

This week, you'll learn what collocations are and why they're essential for sounding natural when speaking English. We'll explore a variety of collocations, from beginner to advanced levels, helping you build your vocabulary and improve your fluency. You'll discover how to use strong collocations in everyday speech and writing. Get ready to take your English to the next level with this fun and informative collocation challenge!



What are collocations?

Collocations are **combinations of words that appear together often and sound natural** to people who speak a language fluently. So, learning collocations is essential if you want to sound natural when speaking English.

Let's look at **'make'** or **'have a party'**. 'Make a party' doesn't sound right to English speakers. The correct collocation is **'have a party'**. For example,

- I **had a party** for my birthday.

However, many collocations are not "right" or "wrong" but are just not as natural as others. An example of this is **'furiously cold'**. We don't hear these words together often, but it's not wrong. In fact, **'It was a furiously cold day!'** sounds like a line from a novel! But a much more natural, stronger collocation is **'bitterly cold'**. For example,

- It was **bitterly cold** when I went out this morning.

In this lesson, I'm going to teach you strong collocations that you can use in everyday speech.

 Beginner: A1 /A2

Are you ready for your first test? Let's get started with the first question.

1 Which verb can you use to complete the sentence?

I _____ **yoga every morning.**

- a. make
- b. do

The correct answer is **do /du:/**. We 'do yoga'. We also 'do karate' and 'do exercise'. We don't 'make yoga'.

2 Which preposition is missing from this sentence?

I argued with my brother _____ **whose turn it was to use the car.**

We should have **about /ə'baʊt/** or **over /'əʊvə/**. There are two possible answers! We can argue about something or over something.

3 Complete the sentence with a word that starts with 'w'.

When the weather is nice, I like to go for a w_____.

The correct answer is **walk /wɔ:k/**. 'To go for a walk' means to walk outside, usually for fun or exercise.

6 Which verb can you use to complete all three sentences?

I always _____ a shower after exercising.

I'm going to _____ an English course next year.

They often _____ photographs of their dog.

Take /terk/ is the correct answer! 'Take a shower' is more common in American English than British English, but people in the UK do use this collocation. In British English, you'll also hear 'have a shower'. 'Take a course' is a strong collocation meaning 'do a course'. And 'take photographs' is also very strong.

Are you ready for the intermediate level? B1 and B2: let's go!

Intermediate: B1/B2

5 Which word would we NOT use to complete the sentence?

When strawberries are ready to eat, they _____ red.

- a. change
- b. go
- c. turn

We would not use **change /tʃeɪndʒ/** in this sentence. You could say 'change to red', but better collocations are 'go red' and 'turn red', both meaning 'become red'.

6 Which adjective collocates best with 'imagination'?

She had a _____ imagination when she was a child.

- a. vivid
- b. bright
- c. shining

That's right: **vivid** /'vɪvɪd/. This is the strongest collocation. If someone has a vivid imagination, they can make very clear images in their mind.

7 Which adjective does NOT form a strong collocation with 'hot' in this sentence?

It was the middle of July and a _____ hot day.

- a. scorching
- b. baking
- c. fiery

Fiery /'faɪəri/. 'A fiery hot day' isn't a strong collocation, but everyone would understand what you mean if you said this. We tend to use 'fiery' as an adjective to describe a person who tends to get angry quickly or easily or to say something looks like or consists of fire.

In everyday speech and writing, 'scorching hot' and 'baking hot' are more natural. 'Baking hot' is particularly common in British English.

Ok, here's the final question for this round.

- 8 Which word can you use to complete all three sentences?
- We often _____ research projects about the animals that live in our local area.**
- Our workplace has a strict code of _____ that all employees must follow.**
- Jackson Blythe and Marie Sato _____ the Philharmonic Orchestra.**

Did you say **conduct** /kən'dʌkt/ - **conduct** /'kɒndʌkt/? Brilliant! Notice the stress shift. In the first and third sentences, 'conduct' /kən'dʌkt/ is a verb, and the stress is on the second syllable. In the second sentence, 'conduct' /'kɒndʌkt/ is a noun, and the stress is on the first syllable.

What do these words mean?

- **conduct research** → do research.
- **a code of conduct** → a code of behaviour or rules for behaviour
- **conduct an orchestra** → you direct the orchestra

Are you ready to move on to some advanced collocations?

Advanced: C1/C2

- 9 Which word best completes the sentence?
- You need to _____ your pride and apologise to him.**
- a. absorb
 - b. consume
 - c. swallow

You should have **swallow** /'swɒləʊ/. If you 'swallow your pride', you decide to do something even though it will make you feel embarrassed and you would prefer not to. You 'hide your pride', though that's not a strong collocation!

10 Which word collocates well with 'error'?

The book contained a few _____ errors, and many readers complained to the publisher.

- a. bleak
- b. crying
- c. glaring

The correct answer is **glaring** /'gleəriŋ/. A 'glaring error' is very obvious. 'Bleak' and 'crying' don't collocate well with 'error'.

11 Which verb can you use to complete all three sentences?

1. Things took an interesting _____ when Evie showed up with her new partner.

2. The sights and smells in the market _____ my stomach.

3. The author had an interesting _____ of phrase that made everything he wrote supremely interesting.

Turn /tɜ:n/. In sentences 1 and 3, 'turn' is a noun. In sentence 2, it is a verb.

- **To take a ... turn** → to change or develop in a certain way. You could say,
 - 'The party took a surprising turn.' (something surprising happened)

If something turns your stomach, it makes you feel ill or upset. And a 'turn of phrase' is a way of describing something.

12 Which of the adverbs does NOT form a strong collocation with 'beautiful' in this sentence?

The morning mist hanging in the valleys made the landscape _____ beautiful.

- a. hauntingly**
- b. creepily**
- c. eerily**

You guessed it: **creepily** /'kri:pəli/. 'Creepily beautiful' is not a strong collocation, though it could work if you wanted to make a powerful impact on your readers or listeners. 'Hauntingly beautiful' means in a way that makes you feel sad and is difficult to forget; 'eerily beautiful' means in a strange or mysterious way.



Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. Collocations are only important for advanced English learners.
 - a. True
 - b. False
2. She has a _____ imagination and loves creating stories.
 - a. vivid
 - b. bright
 - c. shining
3. I always _____ a shower before going to bed.
 - a. make
 - b. do
 - c. take
4. It was a _____ hot day, so we decided to stay indoors.
 - a. scorched
 - b. fiery
 - c. baking
5. 'Make a party' is a strong collocation in English.
 - a. True
 - b. False
6. The report contained several _____ errors that were easily noticeable.
 - a. bleak
 - b. crying
 - c. glaring
7. You need to _____ your pride and apologise to her.
 - a. swallow
 - b. consume
 - c. absorb
8. 'Go red' and 'turn red' are both strong collocations meaning 'become red'.
 - a. True
 - b. False

Answers:

1. b 2. a 3. c 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. a 8. a

